

The Phrases of Metta

मेत्ता भावना *Mettā Bhāvanā*

Metta — loving-kindness — is traditionally offered in a set order, moving outward through five directions: toward oneself, toward someone loved, toward someone neutral, toward someone difficult, and finally toward all beings without exception. The same phrases carry through every direction; only the person addressed changes.

1	2	3	4	5
Self	A Loved Person	A Neutral Person	A Difficult Person	All Beings
"May I..."	"May you..."	"May you..."	"May you..."	"May all beings..."

Each phrase below is given with "you" — substitute "I" for self, or "all beings" for the final direction.

BODY & WELLBEING

May you be happy	May you be well
May you be healthy	May you be healthy and strong
May you be free of pain	May you be free of illness and pain
May you never be hungry	May you always have all that you need to be comfortable

SAFETY & EASE

May you be safe	May you feel at ease
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EMOTIONAL & MENTAL PEACE

May your emotions be calm	May you be free of anger
May you be free of jealousy	May you be free of hatred
May your mind be calm and still	May you be at peace

FREEDOM & LIBERATION

May you be free of suffering	May you be liberated
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BEYOND THE LIST

These phrases are not a fixed script. They can be adapted, extended, and hooked together into longer sentences of your own — for example: *"May you be healthy and strong — strong enough to bear the burdens of your life with ease, with peace."* There is no single correct wording, and no ceiling on how far a phrase can be built out.

Students should never feel confined to this list, or to using only one sentence at a time. What matters is not the exact words but the feeling and emotion carried behind them — the words are simply a vehicle for that feeling. Encourage students to let their own language arise once the feeling itself is genuinely present.

Practice Note — There is no need to use every phrase in every sitting. A small handful, repeated slowly and felt rather than recited, carries more than the full list rushed through. Let each phrase settle before moving to the next, and allow the feeling behind the words to lead — the words are a support for the feeling, not a substitute for it.

